

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · BEDTIME COMPANION

The House of Wisdom in Baghdad

A Night of Paper and Ink, 850s CE

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

A map of Baghdad and its rivers, the long story of paper and books, the real people and places behind the night, and a short list of trusted books and places to visit, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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Baghdad and the Tigris

Let's begin by finding our way to the city on the Tigris.



Baghdad, Samarra, Kufa and Basra plotted at their real modern locations on a base map (Natural Earth). Rivers and canals have shifted a long way since the ninth century, and the Sarat canal is not drawn. The caliphs ruled from Samarra from 836 until about 892; in the episode, no caliph walks the streets of Baghdad.

AT A GLANCE

- A quiet night in the 850s, on the west bank of the Tigris
- The round City of Peace, laid out in 762
- Paper sold by the rizmah, the bundle that gave us the word ream
- The caliph's library stays a name in the background

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Places you'll visit in the episode

A short, slow tour of the places behind the story.

The hired workroom · An imagined rented room on the west bank, where a translator, a copyist and a bookseller work through a night in the 850s.

The round City of Peace · Madinat al-Salam, laid out by al-Mansur in 762; later writers describe a moat, a double wall and four gates.

The four gates · Named for the roads beyond them: Khurasan to the north-east, Basra to the south-east, Kufa to the south-west and Syria to the north-west.

The Green Dome and the great mosque · The only two great buildings the old accounts place in the empty central court.

A courtyard house · Mud-brick houses turn inward around a cool court, and a reader finishes his book in one.

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Places you'll visit in the episode

The stationers' row · About 891, al-Ya'qubi counts more than a hundred shops of stationers and copyists in the Wadhdhah quarter.

Al-Karkh · The market district where, in 773 or the year after, al-Mansur moved the trades, each craft in its own row.

The Sarat canal · Brings Euphrates water across toward the Tigris, one channel in a wide net of waterways.

The bank of the Tigris · A round pitch-coated boat called a guffa rests in the mist; the shape is old, though no writing from these years describes one at this bank.

The caliph's library · Bayt al-Hikma, the House of Wisdom, also called the Store of Wisdom; scholars doubt it was an academy, and the episode keeps it as a name.

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From the round city to the Fihrist

Here is the long story of paper and books, one date at a time.

THE STORY AT A GLANCE

762	About 800	The 850s	987–988
The round city	Greek on Arab paper	Our night	The Fihrist

The workroom and the five people in it are imagined. The city, the paper and the scholars named in the old catalogues are real. Dates are approximate where the sources are.

762 Al-Mansur lays out the round City of Peace, Madinat al-Salam, on the west bank of the Tigris.

773 or 774 Al-Mansur moves the trades out to al-Karkh, each craft in its own row.

786 Harun al-Rashid becomes caliph. By about 794 or 795 paper workshops are at work in Baghdad.

About 800 The oldest surviving manuscript on Arab paper, a Greek one, is probably copied in Damascus.

809 Hunayn ibn Ishaq is born, a Christian from al-Hira who will translate Greek medicine.

813–833 Al-Ma'mun is caliph, and pays for translations and for the sun watches.

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From the night to the catalogue

The night passes, and later writers set down what they knew.



About 825 Al-Khwarizmi's manual of Hindu reckoning, written for a board of dust.

836 The caliphs make Samarra their capital, until about 892.

The 850s Our night: a translator, a copyist, a bookseller, a reader and a messenger.

Late 866 A book on paper dated to these months is the oldest Arabic book on paper that survives.

About 891 Al-Ya'qubi counts more than a hundred stationers' shops in the Wadhdhah quarter.

987–988 Ibn al-Nadim sets down the Fihrist, the catalogue that names the keepers of the caliph's library.

Many details of pens, ink and copying come from guides written after this night, so they show the craft rather than this exact room.

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THE WIDER WORLD

Where paper and books travelled

Now let's look at the wider world that paper and books travelled through.



Approximate extent of the Abbasid Caliphate around 800 CE, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset.

FROM FAR AND NEAR

- Muslims met paper in Central Asia, and Samarkand grew famous for it
- The oldest Greek manuscript on Arab paper was probably copied in Damascus
- Hunayn's search for one Greek book reached as far as Alexandria

People you'll meet

The real names, and a few imagined ones, that you'll hear along the way.

Dawud & Nafi · Imagined: a translator who works for the sense of a passage, and the copyist who makes the fair copy and checks it by ear.

Layla, Harith & Ibrahim · Imagined: a bookseller who sells paper by the rizmah, a messenger with a folded request, and a young reader.

Abu Ja'far al-Mansur · Laid out the round City of Peace in 762, and moved the trades to al-Karkh.

Harun al-Rashid · Caliph from 786, in whose reign workshops were making paper in Baghdad.

Al-Ma'mun · Caliph from 813 to 833, who paid for translations. The dream of Aristotle is a tale the Fihrist tells.

Hunayn ibn Ishaq · Born in 809, a Christian from al-Hira; he gathered many copies of a book and compared them before translating.

Muhammad, Ahmad & al-Hasan · The three sons of Musa ibn Shakir, wards of al-Ma'mun, who sponsored translators. Muhammad died in 873.

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People you'll meet

Al-Khwarizmi · Wrote a manual of Hindu reckoning, an algebra and tables for al-Ma'mun; he died about 850.

Thabit ibn Qurra · A scholar from Harran who came into the brothers' circle, and died in Baghdad in 901.

Ibn al-Nadim · A bookseller of Baghdad whose Fihrist of 987 and 988 lists the keepers of the caliph's library.

Al-Ya'qubi · A geographer who, about 891, described the markets and stationers' shops.

Al-Razi · A physician who lived from 865 to 925; one late copy of his treatise on the scribe's craft gives seven ink recipes.

Al-Jahiz · The great writer of Basra and Baghdad, said to have rented stationers' shops by the day to read their books.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, and what is real

A few small things to listen for, and a note on what is found and what is imagined.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- A pen cut from a reed and split at the tip, on a small cutting board called a miqatt
- A sheet of brown, polished paper, sized with starch so the ink sits
- Faint laid lines in the paper, left by the mould
- A correction in the margin, marked sahh, with a curved mark pointing to it
- A board of dust where a sum is wiped away with the side of the hand
- A round boat, a guffa, made of branches, palm fronds and pitch

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT WE IMAGINE

Baghdad, the Tigris, the paper and the caliph's library are real, and so are the scholars named in the old catalogues. Dawud, Nafi, Harith, Layla and Ibrahim are imagined. Historians still debate what the House of Wisdom was, and the episode does not describe its rooms.





Artistic impressions of a reed pen on a sheet of paper, and of a round boat on the Tigris at first light, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Greek Thought, Arabic Culture ↗, Dimitri Gutas (Routledge, 1998).

Paper Before Print ↗, Jonathan M. Bloom (Yale University Press, 2001).

The Fihrist of al-Nadim ↗, trans. and ed. Bayard Dodge (Columbia University Press, 1970; two volumes, often found in libraries).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗



An artistic impression made for the episode, not a historical record.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Chester Beatty, Dublin: its Islamic collections include Arabic manuscripts on papyrus, parchment and paper, among them early Arabic translations of Greek works.

Aga Khan Museum, Toronto: a museum of Islamic art and Muslim cultures.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you had one quiet night in that workroom, would you choose the reed pen, or the board of dust where a mistake costs only a sweep of the hand?

"The lamp burns lower, the reed pen lies where it was set down, and the river keeps its soft, even sound all through the night."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

Watch the episode: youtube.com/watch?v=jAIuxlQopjo

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